

Psalms 78

Lessons from History

That the generation to come might know them
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Give ear, O my people, to my law: incline your ears to the words of my mouth.
- 2 I will open my mouth in a parable: I will utter dark sayings of old:
- 3 Which we have heard and known, and our fathers have told us.
- 4 We will not hide them from their children, shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, and his strength, and his wonderful works that he hath done.
- 5 For he established a testimony in Jacob, and appointed a law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers, that they should make them known to their children:
- 6 That the generation to come might know them, even the children which should be born; who should arise and declare them to their children:
- 7 That they might set their hope in God, and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments:
- 8 And might not be as their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation; a generation that set not their heart aright, and whose spirit was not stedfast with God.
- 9 The children of Ephraim, being armed, and carrying bows, turned back in the day of battle.
- 10 They kept not the covenant of God, and refused to walk in his law;
- 11 And forgat his works, and his wonders that he had shewed them.
- 12 Marvellous things did he in the sight of their fathers, in the land of Egypt, in the field of Zoan.
- 13 He divided the sea, and caused them to pass through; and he made the waters to stand as an heap.
- 14 In the daytime also he led them with a cloud, and all the night with a light of fire.
- 15 He clave the rocks in the wilderness, and gave them drink as out of the great depths.
- 16 He brought streams also out of the rock, and caused waters to run down like rivers.
- 17 And they sinned yet more against him by provoking the most High in the wilderness.
- 18 And they tempted God in their heart by asking meat for their lust.
- 19 Yea, they spake against God; they said, Can God furnish a table in the wilderness?
- 20 Behold, he smote the rock, that the waters gushed out, and the streams overflowed; can he give bread also? can he provide flesh for his people?
- 21 Therefore the LORD heard this, and was wroth: so a fire was kindled against Jacob, and anger also came up against Israel;
- 22 Because they believed not in God, and trusted not in his salvation:
- 23 Though he had commanded the clouds from above, and opened the doors of heaven,
- 24 And had rained down manna upon them to eat, and had given them of the corn of heaven.
- 25 Man did eat angels' food: he sent them meat to the full.
- 26 He caused an east wind to blow in the heaven: and by his power he brought in the south wind.
- 27 He rained flesh also upon them as dust, and feathered fowls like as the sand of the sea:
- 28 And he let it fall in the midst of their camp, round about their habitations.
- 29 So they did eat, and were well filled: for he gave them their own desire;
- 30 They were not estranged from their lust. But while their meat was yet in their mouths,
- 31 The wrath of God came upon them, and slew the fattest of them, and smote down the chosen men of Israel.
- 32 For all this they sinned still, and believed not for his wondrous works.
- 33 Therefore their days did he consume in vanity, and their years in trouble.
- 34 When he slew them, then they sought him: and they returned and enquired early after God.
- 35 And they remembered that God was their rock, and the high God their redeemer.
- 36 Nevertheless they did flatter him with their mouth, and they lied unto him with their tongues.
- 37 For their heart was not right with him, neither were they stedfast in his covenant.

38 But he, being full of compassion, forgave their iniquity, and destroyed them not: yea, many a time turned he his anger away, and did not stir up all his wrath.
 39 For he remembered that they were but flesh; a wind that passeth away, and cometh not again.
 40 How oft did they provoke him in the wilderness, and grieve him in the desert!
 41 Yea, they turned back and tempted God, and limited the Holy One of Israel.
 42 They remembered not his hand, nor the day when he delivered them from the enemy.
 43 How he had wrought his signs in Egypt, and his wonders in the field of Zoan:
 44 And had turned their rivers into blood; and their floods, that they could not drink.
 45 He sent divers sorts of flies among them, which devoured them; and frogs, which destroyed them.
 46 He gave also their increase unto the caterpillar, and their labour unto the locust.
 47 He destroyed their vines with hail, and their sycamore trees with frost.
 48 He gave up their cattle also to the hail, and their flocks to hot thunderbolts.
 49 He cast upon them the fierceness of his anger, wrath, and indignation, and trouble, by sending evil angels among them.
 50 He made a way to his anger; he spared not their soul from death, but gave their life over to the pestilence;
 51 And smote all the firstborn in Egypt; the chief of their strength in the tabernacles of Ham:
 52 But made his own people to go forth like sheep, and guided them in the wilderness like a flock.
 53 And he led them on safely, so that they feared not: but the sea overwhelmed their enemies.
 54 And he brought them to the border of his sanctuary, even to this mountain, which his right hand had purchased.
 55 He cast out the heathen also before them, and divided them an inheritance by line, and made the tribes of Israel to dwell in their tents.
 56 Yet they tempted and provoked the most high God, and kept not his testimonies:
 57 But turned back, and dealt unfaithfully like their fathers: they were turned aside like a deceitful bow.
 58 For they provoked him to anger with their high places, and moved him to jealousy with their graven images.
 59 When God heard this, he was wroth, and greatly abhorred Israel:
 60 So that he forsook the tabernacle of Shiloh, the tent which he placed among men;
 61 And delivered his strength into captivity, and his glory into the enemy's hand.
 62 He gave his people over also unto the sword; and was wroth with his inheritance.
 63 The fire consumed their young men; and their maidens were not given to marriage.
 64 Their priests fell by the sword; and their widows made no lamentation.
 65 Then the Lord awaked as one out of sleep, and like a mighty man that shouteth by reason of wine.
 66 And he smote his enemies in the hinder parts: he put them to a perpetual reproach.
 67 Moreover he refused the tabernacle of Joseph, and chose not the tribe of Ephraim:
 68 But chose the tribe of Judah, the mount Zion which he loved.
 69 And he built his sanctuary like high palaces, like the earth which he hath established for ever.
 70 He chose David also his servant, and took him from the sheepfolds:
 71 From following the ewes great with young he brought him to feed Jacob his people, and Israel his inheritance.
 72 So he fed them according to the integrity of his heart; and guided them by the skilfulness of his hands.

2 • CONTEXT

This lengthy Maschil of Asaph retells Israel's history from the exodus through David's rise as a sustained argument: God has been consistently faithful even as generation after generation has been consistently unfaithful. Its stated purpose in the opening verses is pedagogical—so that children not yet born will learn to set their hope in God rather than repeat their ancestors' rebellion. Henry calls it a summary sermon on covenant history; MacArthur-style notes highlight the pattern of provision, provocation, judgment, and renewed mercy that repeats across the psalm.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Asaph calls Israel to attend to a parable, dark sayings from of old, heard from the fathers and now to be told to the next generation—the psalm announces itself as a teaching tool from its first line.

Verse 5-8

God established His law and testimony in Israel precisely so fathers would teach children, so that the coming generation would set its hope in God and not forget His works—unlike the fathers, described bluntly as a stubborn and rebellious generation whose spirit was not steadfast.

Verse 9-16

Ephraim's failure in battle is cited as an example of covenant-breaking despite having witnessed God's wonders in Egypt. The psalm then recalls the sea dividing, the pillar of cloud and fire, and water miraculously drawn from rock in the wilderness—vivid, undeniable evidence of God's power available to that generation.

Verse 17-22

Despite all this, the people sinned further, testing God by demanding food to satisfy their appetite and openly doubting whether He could even provide a table in the wilderness. God's anger burned specifically because they refused to trust His power to save, not merely because they complained.

Verse 23-29

Yet God answered doubt with abundance: commanding the skies to open, raining down manna—'angels' food'—and sending flocks of birds like sand of the sea into the camp, giving the people exactly what their own appetite had craved.

Verse 30-33

Even mid-meal, judgment fell: God struck down the strongest among them while they were still unsatisfied, because for all this they still did not believe. Their days were consumed in emptiness, their years in trouble—abundance without trust still ended in loss.

Verse 34-39

A cycle emerges: when struck, they sought God again, remembering He was their Rock, yet their repentance was shallow—flattering with their lips while their hearts remained unfaithful to the covenant. Remarkably, God's compassion repeatedly held back deserved wrath, remembering they were merely flesh, like a wind that passes and does not return.

Verse 40-43

The psalm names the pattern directly: how often they provoked, grieved, and limited the Holy One of Israel in the wilderness, forgetting the day of deliverance from the enemy and the signs and wonders performed in Egypt.

Verse 44-51

The plagues are recounted in sequence—rivers turned to blood, swarms of flies and frogs, crops destroyed by locust and hail, livestock struck down, culminating in the death of Egypt's firstborn—demonstrating God's total, escalating power over a hostile empire.

Verse 52-55

In contrast, God's own people were led out like a flock, guided safely through the wilderness while their enemies were engulfed by the sea, and finally brought to the border of the promised land, inheritance divided among the tribes by His own hand.

Verse 56-64

Yet even in the land, the pattern repeated: testing and provoking God again, turning back like an unreliable bow, provoking Him with idols at high places. God's response was severe—forsaking the tabernacle at Shiloh, allowing defeat and captivity, priests falling by the sword, and widows left unable even to properly mourn.

Verse 65-72

The psalm's resolution arrives with God 'awaking' in decisive judgment against the enemy, then choosing Judah and Mount Zion over Ephraim's tribe, building His sanctuary there, and—climactically—choosing David, taken from tending sheep, to shepherd His people Jacob with integrity of heart and skillful hands. History's long, repeating failure ends not in Israel's success but in God's sovereign choice of a faithful shepherd-king.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Israel's history, honestly retold, is a repeating cycle of divine provision met by human forgetfulness and provocation, met again by divine judgment and renewed mercy. The psalm's ultimate answer to this cycle is not a better generation but God's own sovereign choice—raising up David as a shepherd after His own heart—foreshadowing that the solution to persistent unfaithfulness comes from God's initiative, not human improvement.

Application for life today.

Use this psalm to examine your own spiritual memory: do you, like Israel, tend to forget God's specific past provisions once the pressure that prompted them has passed? Notice the danger named in verses 17–22 and 40–43—doubting God's power even after having witnessed it—and ask where that doubt quietly persists in your own life despite evidence to the contrary. Take comfort that God's solution to repeated human failure has always been His own gracious initiative, ultimately fulfilled in the greater Shepherd-

King, Christ.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where do you see the pattern of 'forget, provoke, judge, restore' playing out in your own spiritual life, as it does throughout Israel's history here?

2. What specific past deliverance from God do you need to deliberately teach or pass on to the next generation (vv. 4–7), rather than let it fade?

3. How does God's choice of David—taken from sheepfolds, not from any obvious qualification (vv. 70–72)—encourage you about how God works through weakness?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).